

FLOODED Lakes form in the Little Rann of Kutch

High Court. "The demands are invariably higher than what's needed, yet the engineers will simply comply. It's not a systematic, documented process."

That leaves plenty unused water. And the topography is such that this spills over from the canals, travels 15-20 km across open land, rivulets, ravines and villages, and eventually drains into the Rann. "There, it accumulates into a vast saltwater lake, but also washes out salt pans. At least 8,500 *agariyas* (salt pan workers) have lost their livelihoods due to this flooding," Prajapati adds.

Takeaways

- **Unused Narmada water goes waste, floods the Little Rann of Kutch, a unique microhabitat**
- **Ad hoc practices lead to colossal waste of water, destroys age-old salt pans**
- **Permanent flood alters Rann ecology: alien weeds, trees disturb native species**

LOST VOCATION

Kalubhai Thakor, a salt farmer from Vachhrajpura village in Patadi taluka, says half his strip was flooded in June as the waters gushed in earlier than expected. "The Rann has become a sea. We had to return in a boat to collect our belongings," he says. His makeshift residence and solar panel, all were gone—devastating enough to force him into taking a soul-crushing step. "Many like me have decided to abandon salt farming and migrate to towns to work on construction sites," Kalubhai says, ruing the loss of an arduous but cherished traditional occupation. Moreover, wage labour won't make ends meet or fund the education of his two children.

Shockingly, such flooding started in 2014 but it's only in 2025 that remedial action is coming. "The departments of irrigation, agriculture, forests, SSNNL, district collectorates...they were all in denial that this is Narmada water. We proved it through years of onground and drone video documentation," says Bharat Somera, an *agariya*-turned-activist in Patadi, one of the towns bordering the Rann in Surendranagar. Given the salinity ingress in the soil, the excess water that flows past dozens of villages can't be used for irrigation, says Prajapati. What's going waste is water denied to thousands of farmers elsewhere in Gujarat.

ECO-ILLOGICAL

The foreign waters have impacted the ecology: it carries exotic weeds that displace native Rann grassland species. Also, the IUCN has documented how it restricts the movement of the Asiatic Wild Ass and other species in their unique microhabitat. This has resulted in human-animal conflict as the Wild Ass, numbered 7,672 in a 2024 census, spill out into surrounding farmlands.

Exasperated activists say the forest department is secretly happy, as the wet Rann is attracting migratory birds and causing a new profusion of *vilayati keekar*, another invasive species. The accidental greening looks good at first. "As the word spreads among bird-watchers, tourism is picking up," Somera says.

In its July report to the SHRC, Prajapati and co-panelist Neha Sarwate seek a cessation to the ad-hoc release of water, to plug the problem at source, with village WUAs set up urgently. All departments see the wisdom in this, but waver in intent. No deadlines are forthcoming, no promises. Instead, they have accepted other suggested steps: desilting existing check dams, building new ones, ramping up village pond capacities, desilting rivers. All these to take in excess waters—tending to the milk after it has spilt, as it were. Prajapati also fears a frustrating wait before any actual action, what with feasibility surveys, approval of budgets running into "thousands of crores", tendering et al.

Pankti Jog of the Agariya Hitrakshak Committee, one of the first petitioners, cites other issues: "In many villages, minor and sub-minor canals to the fields haven't been built. That adds to the colossal wastage." SSNNL officials are muted, hinting at circumscribed powers amidst a plethora of authorities. Life, meanwhile, has come full circle for Prajapati, who was associated with the Narmada Bachao Andolan in the '90s. "Water wastage was one of our primary concerns then," he says wistfully. ■